DATA-DRIVEN ATHLETE MARKETING

Conversion Units, Marketing Spend & Brand ROI Case Study

How brands can shift from paying for fame to investing in athlete relevance - identifying high-potential talent before pricing peaks.

India-focused strategic model | Small, Mid-market & Enterprise brands | 2026 planning framework

Founder working model - for investor, brand and GTM discussions. Financial outputs below are scenario estimates, not guaranteed campaign results.

1. Executive Summary

The core ADC thesis is simple: conventional sports and influencer marketing often buys **current popularity**. ADC aims to buy **future relevance** by identifying athletes earlier using verified performance, audience, growth, geography and brand-fit data. If a brand can reach a relevant audience through emerging athletes before their endorsement prices inflate, the same rupee can purchase more qualified attention and more measurable conversion opportunities.

2.06x	33%	4.58x	50-60%
modelled conversion units per ■1L	lower modelled CPM	modelled revenue ROAS	suggested ADC budget share for emerging-athlete campaigns

Important: 2.06x and 4.58x are ADC planning outputs derived from the assumptions in this report. They are not external market benchmarks. The model is intentionally transparent so ADC can replace assumptions with live campaign data over time.

Market context

Signal	Current evidence	Implication for ADC
India sports economy	■18,864 Cr in 2025; sports sponsorship ■7,943 Cr; sports media spend ■9,571 Cr	Large and growing pool of brand capital
Athlete endorsements	■1,350 Cr in 2025; cricket accounted for 87%	Long-tail athletes remain comparatively under-commercialised
Influencer marketing	■3,600 Cr in 2024; WPP/Kantar forecast 25% growth in 2025	Brands are already comfortable buying creator-led reach
Measurement maturity	83% of surveyed brands use links/codes/affiliate dashboards; 50% report influencer ROI better than or equal to digital performance ads	ADC should sell measurement, not only discovery

2. Brand Spend Architecture: Small vs Mid vs Enterprise

There is no single universal marketing budget for an Indian brand. The table below is a **planning archetype** for ADC sales conversations, not a claim that every company in the segment spends this amount. The model assumes a sports/influencer activation equals 25% of the illustrative annual marketing budget.

Brand archetype	Illustrative annual marketing budget	Sports / creator activation pool (25%)	Typical objective	ADC entry product
Small / emerging	■12 Lakh	■3 Lakh	Local discovery + first 500-1,500 qualified actions	Campaign starter
Mid-market / D2C	■60 Lakh	■15 Lakh	Regional scale + measurable acquisition	Always-on athlete portfolio
Enterprise	■3 Crore	■75 Lakh	Multi-market reach + brand lift + acquisition	Portfolio intelligence + campaign OS

Where conventional spend leaks

A conventional campaign can lose efficiency through creator/athlete discovery, agency mark-ups, weak audience fit, inflated pricing based on follower count, duplicated reach, manual contracting, poor attribution and late entry into an athlete's commercial journey. One 2026 industry pricing guide estimates discovery, contracting and tracking can consume 30-40% of influencer program budgets; treat this as directional rather than universal.

ADC's economic opportunity is therefore not simply 'cheaper athletes'. It is **better allocation**: identify an athlete whose performance trajectory, geography, audience, engagement quality and category fit indicate that ■1 spent today has a higher probability of producing relevant reach than ■1 spent on a generic high-follower asset.

ADC allocation funnel

1. Discover	2. Score	3. Price	4. Activate	5. Attribute	6. Learn
Verified athlete pool	Performance + Social + Brand Match	Expected CPM/CPE + growth premium	Right athlete / market / content	Reach -> click -> conversion	Update athlete & brand scores

3. The ADC Conversion Unit (CU)

To make brand ROI comparable across athletes and campaigns, ADC can define a standard **Conversion Unit (CU)**. For this case study, 1 CU = one attributed commercial action such as purchase, qualified lead, app install, trial signup or verified store redemption. The brand chooses the event; ADC normalises cost per CU.

Metric	Conventional macro / generic campaign	ADC data-matched emerging-athlete campaign	Why ADC can improve it
Effective CPM	■180	■120	Earlier-stage talent + portfolio buying
CTR / qualified action rate	0.80%	1.00%	Better audience/category/geography fit
Conversion rate after click	2.00%	2.20%	Higher relevance and authenticity
Average order / attributed value	■2,500	■2,500	Held constant to isolate media efficiency

Per ■1 Lakh campaign spend	Conventional	ADC model	ADC uplift
Impressions	5.56 Lakh	8.33 Lakh	+50%
Clicks / qualified visits	4,444	8,333	+88%
Conversion Units	89	183	+106%
Cost per CU	■1,125	■545	-52%
Attributed revenue	■2.22 Lakh	■4.58 Lakh	+106%
Revenue ROAS	2.22x	4.58x	2.06x

Formula: Impressions = Spend / CPM × 1,000. Clicks = Impressions × CTR. CU = Clicks × conversion rate. Revenue ROAS = CU × attributed value / spend.

Interpretation: Under these assumptions, ADC does not need an athlete to be 'famous'. It needs the athlete portfolio to produce enough improvement in effective CPM + relevance to reduce cost per conversion from ■1,125 to ~■545.

4. Full Brand Case Studies

SMALL BRAND: Sports nutrition / local D2C

Activation spend	■3L activation	Model assumes same spend in both approaches
Conventional attributed revenue	■6.67L	2.22x revenue ROAS
ADC attributed revenue	■13.75L	4.58x revenue ROAS
Conventional Conversion Units	267	~89 CU per ■1L
ADC Conversion Units	550	~183 CU per ■1L
Gross profit @ 45% margin - conventional	■3.00L	Illustrative contribution before fixed costs
Gross profit @ 45% margin - ADC	■7.08L	Illustrative contribution before fixed costs

MID-MARKET: Sportswear / wellness / fintech

Activation spend	■15L activation	Model assumes same spend in both approaches
Conventional attributed revenue	■33.33L	2.22x revenue ROAS
ADC attributed revenue	■68.75L	4.58x revenue ROAS
Conventional Conversion Units	1,333	~89 CU per ■1L
ADC Conversion Units	2,750	~183 CU per ■1L
Gross profit @ 45% margin - conventional	■15.00L	Illustrative contribution before fixed costs
Gross profit @ 45% margin - ADC	■35.42L	Illustrative contribution before fixed costs

ENTERPRISE: FMCG / auto / BFSI / consumer tech

Activation spend	■75L activation	Model assumes same spend in both approaches
Conventional attributed revenue	■1.67Cr	2.22x revenue ROAS
ADC attributed revenue	■3.44Cr	4.58x revenue ROAS
Conventional Conversion Units	6,667	~89 CU per ■1L
ADC Conversion Units	13,750	~183 CU per ■1L
Gross profit @ 45% margin - conventional	■75.00L	Illustrative contribution before fixed costs
Gross profit @ 45% margin - ADC	■1.77Cr	Illustrative contribution before fixed costs

These are unit-economics scenarios. They deliberately hold product price/value constant. In a live deployment, ADC should calculate incremental lift using holdout geographies, coupon/control codes or matched audience cohorts.

5. Why 'Before They Make It Big' Changes the Economics

Athlete endorsement pricing is nonlinear: once an athlete reaches a national league, international event, viral moment or major medal, scarcity and attention can reprice the asset rapidly. ADC's defensibility comes from identifying commercial potential **before** this repricing event.

Portfolio strategy	Illustrative fee per athlete	Athletes activated with ■10L	Risk	Commercial logic
1 established / celebrity asset	■10L	1	Concentration	Maximum reach, weak diversification
5 rising athletes	■2L	5	Medium	Regional + sport diversification
20 emerging athletes	■50K	20	Distributed	Many shots on performance & audience breakout
ADC blended portfolio	■1L anchor + ■45K x 20	21	Data-managed	One anchor + long-tail discovery portfolio

ADC Alpha concept: If 2 of 20 emerging athletes outperform and their market price rises 4x, the brand has already locked in content/association at the pre-breakout price. This is analogous to portfolio optionality: most athletes deliver targeted local reach, while a few may create disproportionate earned-media upside.

Suggested athlete selection score

Dimension	Weight	Example signals
Brand Match	30%	Category fit, audience demographics, geography, language, values
Performance Trajectory	25%	Recent form, consistency, competition strength, age curve
Audience Quality	20%	Real engagement, follower growth, saves/shares, regional concentration
Commercial Efficiency	15%	Expected CPM/CPE/CU vs asking price
Risk & Reliability	10%	Brand safety, injury/availability, compliance, delivery history

6. Visibility: What a Brand Should Actually Expect

Raw impressions are not enough. ADC should report visibility in layers so a brand can distinguish 'seen' from 'commercially useful'.

Layer	Metric	ADC definition	Why it matters
V1 - Reach	Unique reach / impressions	How many people had an opportunity to see	Top-of-funnel scale
V2 - Attention	Video completion, saves, shares, engaged views	Evidence the audience noticed	Creative resonance
V3 - Relevance	Target-market qualified reach	Audience matches geography/category/persona	Reduces wasted reach
V4 - Intent	Clicks, profile visits, searches, coupon views	Observable commercial interest	Bridges awareness to action
V5 - Conversion	Purchase, lead, install, trial, redemption	ADC Conversion Unit	Comparable unit economics
V6 - Earned lift	Organic mentions, reposts, search lift, follower lift	Unpaid spillover after activation	Breakout-athlete upside

Brand ROI scorecard

KPI	Formula	Target direction
Effective CPM	Spend / impressions × 1,000	Down
Cost per engaged view	Spend / engaged views	Down
Cost per qualified reach	Spend / target-audience reach	Down
Cost per CU	Spend / attributed conversions	Down
Revenue ROAS	Attributed revenue / spend	Up
Gross-profit ROI	(Attributed gross profit - spend) / spend	Up
Athlete Alpha	Post-breakout market fee / contracted fee	Up
Portfolio hit rate	Athletes beating target CU / athletes activated	Up

7. ADC Revenue Model Aligned to Brand ROI

ADC should avoid a model where it earns more merely because the brand spends more. A stronger pitch is a hybrid of intelligence subscription + campaign fee + performance upside.

Brand tier	Suggested ADC subscription	Campaign / transaction fee	Performance component	Indicative annual ADC revenue / account
Small	■7,500/month	8% of managed spend	Optional 3% of incremental attributed revenue	■1.1L-■1.8L
Mid	■25,000/month	6%	2% of incremental attributed revenue	■4L-■7L
Enterprise	■75,000/month	4%	1-2% of incremental attributed revenue	■12L-■25L

Why this aligns incentives: subscription pays for discovery/intelligence infrastructure; campaign fee pays for execution; performance fee rewards ADC only when the brand creates incremental commercial value. Over time, the platform can benchmark every athlete using observed CPM, CPE, CU, conversion rate and price trajectory.

The north-star ratio

ADC Marketing Efficiency Ratio (MER-A) = Attributed Gross Profit from Athlete Campaigns / Total Athlete Marketing Spend.

At 45% gross margin, the case-study model produces conventional gross-profit MER-A of ~1.00x versus ADC ~2.06x. That means each ■1 of athlete marketing spend is modelled to create about ■2.06 of attributed gross profit under the ADC assumptions. For investor materials, present this as a **target model to validate**, not a historical result.

8. 90-Day Validation Pilot

Phase	Weeks	What ADC does	Success gate
Baseline	1-2	Import prior campaigns; establish CPM, CPE, CTR, CVR and athlete fees	Baseline CU economics approved
Discover	2-3	Score 100-500 athletes; shortlist 15-30 by brand fit	Top 10% score cohort selected
Activate	4-8	Run matched campaigns with unique codes/links and geo cohorts	At least 10 athletes activated
Compare	8-10	Compare against conventional creator/athlete control group	20%+ lower cost per qualified reach
Scale	11-12	Shift spend toward winning athlete cohorts	Target 25%+ lower cost per CU

Recommended promise to brands: Do not promise 2x ROI before evidence exists. Promise transparent measurement and a controlled pilot designed to find whether ADC can reduce cost per qualified reach and cost per conversion. Once ADC has 20-50 campaigns, replace planning assumptions with percentile benchmarks by sport, geography, athlete tier and brand category.

Data ADC must capture

Athlete fee and deliverables; verified audience size; geography; engagement quality; performance trajectory; sport/position; competition level; social growth; brand category fit; campaign impressions; unique reach; engaged views; clicks; coupon/code events; conversions; attributed revenue; repeat purchase; earned mentions; post-campaign follower/search lift; and athlete price movement after the campaign.

9. Evidence Base, Assumptions & Sources

External evidence establishes market scale and directional behaviour. ADC-specific efficiency numbers are a scenario model created for this case study and must be validated through pilots.

WPP Media - Sporting Nation 2025 (published Mar 2026)

India sports economy ■18,864 Cr in 2025; media spend ■9,571 Cr; sponsorship ■7,943 Cr; athlete endorsements ■1,350 Cr.

https://www.wppmedia.com/news/sporting-nation-india-sports-sponsorship-report-2025

KPMG India - Sportlight: The Business of Sports in India (2025)

2024 sports ecosystem ■16,633 Cr; emerging/non-cricket sponsorship growth and athlete endorsement context.

https://kpmg.com/in/en/insights/2025/09/sportlight-the-business-of-sports-in-india.html

WPP Media + Kantar - India Influencer Marketing Report 2025

Influencer marketing estimated at ■3,600 Cr in 2024; brands increasingly prioritize content quality and relevance.

https://www.wppmedia.com/news/influencing-with-integrity

Influencer.in - Influencer Marketing Report 2025

83% of surveyed brands track ROI with links/codes/affiliate dashboards; 50% report influencer marketing ROI better than or equal to digital performance ads; majority spend below ■1 Cr annually.

https://www.influencer.in/wp-content/uploads/2025/12/Influencer_Marketing_Report_25.pdf

Kofluence / Economic Times - 2025-26 influencer benchmarks

Regional creator campaigns reported lower campaign costs and stronger engagement than metros; long-term creator partnerships were reported as delivering better ROI by 62% of surveyed brand professionals.

https://economictimes.indiatimes.com/industry/services/advertising/indias-influencer-marketing-industry-to-reach-rs-5000-crore-by-2027-as-creator-economy-formalises-kofluence-report/articleshow/131085735.cms

upGrowth - Influencer Marketing Pricing India 2026

Directional pricing reference; estimates discovery, contracting and tracking at 30-40% of program budgets. Commercial source - use as directional evidence only.

https://upgrowth.in/influencer-marketing-pricing-india-2026/

Model assumptions used in this report

Conventional CPM ■180; ADC CPM ■120; conventional CTR 0.8%; ADC CTR 1.0%; conventional post-click conversion 2.0%; ADC 2.2%; attributed value per conversion ■2,500; gross margin 45%; activation pool = 25% of illustrative annual marketing budget. These are scenario assumptions chosen to demonstrate the mechanics of the ADC model. They are not claimed market averages.

ADC INVESTOR / BRAND TAKEAWAY

ADC is not trying to make sponsorship cheaper by discounting talent. It is trying to make sponsorship more efficient by discovering underpriced relevance - using data to identify athletes whose performance trajectory and audience fit are stronger than their current commercial price.